

A Vertex-Gap Obstruction for Low-Degree Strip Pairs in the Plane Jacobian Conjecture

Dan Clemens* Fable†

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Abstract

Below degree 125, the reduction program of Guccione, Guccione, Valqui and Horruitiner leaves a single open family of possible counterexample degrees to the plane Jacobian conjecture, $(\deg P, \deg Q) = (108, 72)$. One of its two reduced subcases is a pair of parallel Newton-polygon strips carrying the bracket equation $[P, Q] = x^2$. We present a small, fully explicit obstruction theory for such strip pairs: a vertex normalization at a Minkowski vertex, a gap condition on the bottom corners, and a counting argument on a self-contained near-origin block. In the regime $(k, d_2) = (2, 2)$ this forces a contradiction on the generic chart, with an explicit ten-step derivation for the $(8, 28)$ family. We prove the analogous statements at $(2, 3)$ and $(2, 4)$, where the obstruction changes form (support rigidity plus one residue hyperplane), certify rigidity at $(3, 3)$, $(4, 3)$, $(5, 3)$, prove that no near-origin obstruction exists for $k \geq 3$ at $d_2 = 2$, and organize all cells by a conjectural logarithmic-residue functional R_{k, d_2} whose one-term case is the proved $(2, 2)$ obstruction. All claims are machine-verified in exact arithmetic and were adversarially reviewed.

1 Introduction

The Jacobian conjecture of Keller asserts that a polynomial map $F: \mathbb{C}^n \rightarrow \mathbb{C}^n$ with $\det JF$ a nonzero constant is invertible. In July 2026 Alpöge announced an explicit counterexample in dimension three, a cubic map $\mathbb{C}^3 \rightarrow \mathbb{C}^3$ with $\det JF \equiv -2$ carrying three points to a common image [1]. Adding dummy variables, the conjecture is therefore false in every dimension $n \geq 3$, and the two-variable case JC_2 , which remains open, is now the entire content of the problem. The plane case has independent structure: several natural two-variable analogues of the higher-dimensional collapse mechanisms are theorems rather than counterexamples (for instance, graded-equivariant Keller maps of $\mathbb{C}^2$ are automorphisms for every weight pattern [10]), so the search for a plane counterexample, or a proof, runs through finer invariants.

The oldest such invariant is degree. Moh proved that a plane counterexample (P, Q) must have $\max(\deg P, \deg Q) > 100$ [9], and Heitmann described the possible degree pairs and Newton-polygon corners in infinite families [8]. In a different direction, Żołądek [13] and, independently, Sigray in an unpublished thesis [11], bounded the topological degree of a counterexample below by 6. The sharpest current information comes from the program of Guccione, Guccione and Valqui (GGV): a discrete-geometry analysis of the Newton polygons $N(P)$, $N(Q)$ of a

*Email: dc@dcpos.ch.

†Fable is an AI system (Anthropic); see Section 8.

hypothetical counterexample [3, 4, 5], made algorithmic in [6], which tabulates all 34 admissible corner families with $\max(\deg P, \deg Q) \leq 150$. With Horruitiner they raised the degree bound from 100 to 108 [7]. Below 125 exactly one family survives: corner $A_0 = (8, 28)$, degrees $(\deg P, \deg Q) = (108, 72)$.

Proposition 4.3 of [7] reduces this $(8, 28)$ family to two subcases, each a finite algebra problem: find (P, Q) with $[P, Q] := P_x Q_y - P_y Q_x = x^2$, with $N(P)$ and $N(Q)$ contained in two prescribed small polygons and with prescribed vertices attained. In subcase (2) both polygons are narrow lattice *strips* along the direction $(1, 2)$. In the course of a computational campaign that discarded subcase (2) over every field of characteristic zero (conditional on Proposition 4.3 itself; see Section 8), we noticed that the emptiness of the generic chart is not a Gröbner-basis accident. It follows from a short, human-readable substitution chain that ends in the identity $-1 = 0$. This note isolates the mechanism behind that chain, which we call the *vertex-gap obstruction*, and develops it as far as it provably goes.

What the paper proves. For reduced strip pairs with $[P, Q] = x^k$ and strip direction $(1, d_2)$ (Section 2), we establish: (a) two counting propositions, valid for all $k, d_2 \geq 1$, locating a self-contained near-origin block of bracket equations and counting its equations and unknowns (Section 3); (b) the vertex-gap theorem at $(k, d_2) = (2, 2)$: the block is overdetermined by one, the surplus equation reduces to $(\text{unit}) \cdot a_2^2 a_6 \cdot b_{q_0}$, and the chart inverting a_2, a_6 is empty, a statement in the radical (not the ideal) of the block system (Section 3); (c) variant theorems at $(2, 3)$ and $(2, 4)$, where the forced content is instead support rigidity of a P -column plus a single residue hyperplane, together with exact rigidity certificates at $(3, 3)$, $(4, 3)$, $(5, 3)$, and a proof that for every $k \geq 3$ at $d_2 = 2$ no near-origin obstruction exists at all (Section 4); (d) the explicit ten-event collapse for the $(8, 28)$ subcase (2) generic chart (Section 5). A logarithmic-residue functional R_{k, d_2} organizes all of this; its general description of the block variety is stated as a conjecture, of which the $(2, 2)$ theorem is the proved one-term case (Section 6). Section 7 records honestly which GGV families the theory covers, and Section 8 describes the verification methodology, including the role of AI systems in both discovery and adversarial review.

2 Setup: strip pairs, valuations, and the vertex normalization

Throughout, K is a field, $P, Q \in K[x, y]$, and $[P, Q] := P_x Q_y - P_y Q_x$. We write $P = \sum_p a_p x^{p_1} y^{p_2}$ and $Q = \sum_q b_q x^{q_1} y^{q_2}$ over lattice points $p = (p_1, p_2)$, $q = (q_1, q_2) \in \mathbb{Z}_{\geq 0}^2$, and $N(P)$ for the Newton polygon (the convex hull of the support). The whole theory rests on one formula: since

$$[x^{p_1} y^{p_2}, x^{q_1} y^{q_2}] = \det(p, q) x^{p_1+q_1-1} y^{p_2+q_2-1}, \quad \det(p, q) := p_1 q_2 - p_2 q_1,$$

the coefficient of $[P, Q]$ naturally attached to a *Minkowski point* $m \in \mathbb{Z}^2$ is

$$E_m := \sum_{p+q=m} \det(p, q) a_p b_q, \tag{1}$$

the coefficient of the monomial $x^{m_1-1} y^{m_2-1}$. The equation $[P, Q] = x^k$ says exactly: $E_m = 0$ for every m in the Minkowski sum $N(P) + N(Q)$ except $E_{(k+1, 1)} = 1$, since x^k sits at the Minkowski point $(k+1, 1)$. We call the E_m *keys* and index them by m . (The repository artifacts index the same equations by the monomial $(m_1 - 1, m_2 - 1)$; we translate where needed.)

Fix a primitive direction $d = (1, d_2)$ with $d_2 \geq 1$ and define the weight and the level of a lattice point by

$$w(i, j) := d_2 i - j, \quad \ell(i, j) := d_2 i + j.$$

The weight w is constant on lines parallel to d and vanishes on the line $\mathbb{R}d$ through the origin; the level ℓ is injective on each vertical column and orders a strip from the origin outward. Both gradings are additive: $w(p+q) = w(p) + w(q)$, likewise for ℓ . Note that if $w(p) = w(q) = 0$ then p, q are proportional and $\det(p, q) = 0$: the extreme w -stratum of the bracket vanishes identically. This trivial remark does real work below.

Definition 2.1. A *reduced strip pair* of type (k, d_2) consists of P, Q with $[P, Q] = x^k$, $k \geq 1$, such that:

- (S1) $N(P)$ and $N(Q)$ are *strips* along $d = (1, d_2)$: every support point p of P satisfies $0 \leq w(p) \leq w_P$, and every support point q of Q satisfies $0 \leq w(q) \leq w_Q$, for integers $w_P, w_Q \geq 1$; the top edges ($w = 0$) of both polygons lie on the line $\mathbb{R}d$ through the origin.
- (S2) The bottom edges are parallel to d and start at *saturated* bottom corners p_0, q_0 : these are vertices of the polygons, $w(p_0) = w_P$, $w(q_0) = w_Q$, and $a_{p_0} \neq 0$, $b_{q_0} \neq 0$.
- (S3) (Block containment.) P may have support at every lattice point of its strip in columns $x = 1, 2$, and Q in columns $x = k, k+1$; the strips extend at least that far. No support on the y -axis except possibly the origin.

The reader should keep in mind the example that motivated everything, the $(8, 28)$ subcase (2) of [7]: $N(P) = \text{hull}\{(0, 0), (1, 0), (8, 14), (8, 16)\}$ and $N(Q) = \text{hull}\{(0, 0), (2, 1), (12, 21), (12, 24)\}$ with $[P, Q] = x^2$. Here $d = (1, 2)$, $w(i, j) = 2i - j$, P occupies weights $\{0, 1, 2\}$ and Q occupies $\{0, 1, 2, 3\}$, the top edges $(0, 0)$ to $(8, 16)$ and $(0, 0)$ to $(12, 24)$ lie on $\mathbb{R}d$, and the bottom corners are $p_0 = (1, 0)$, $q_0 = (2, 1)$, forced nonzero because Proposition 4.3 prescribes vertex attainment.

The vertex normalization. Where can the right-hand side x^k live? At the Minkowski point $(k+1, 1)$. For a strip pair the natural position for this point is the bottom vertex $p_0 + q_0$ of $N(P) + N(Q)$, the lower endpoint of the long Minkowski edge of direction d obtained by concatenating the two parallel bottom edges. In the motivating example $(3, 1) = (1, 0) + (2, 1)$ is exactly such a vertex. We take this as a hypothesis:

- (i) (*vertex normalization*) $(k+1, 1) = p_0 + q_0$, this is the unique decomposition of $(k+1, 1)$ as a sum of a support point of P and one of Q , and $\det(p_0, q_0) = \pm 1$.

Under (i) the key at the vertex reads $E_{(k+1, 1)} = \det(p_0, q_0) a_{p_0} b_{q_0} = 1$, so both bottom-corner coefficients are units. We call this the *vertex equation*: the valuation of x^k selects the bottom vertex of the tower of parallel edges, and normalizes the corner product. Hypothesis (i) is very rigid:

Lemma 2.2. Under (i), $\{p_0, q_0\} = \{(1, 0), (k, 1)\}$.

Proof. Write $p_0 = (\alpha, \beta)$, $q_0 = (k+1-\alpha, 1-\beta)$ with all entries ≥ 0 , so $\beta \in \{0, 1\}$. If $\beta = 0$ then $\det(p_0, q_0) = \alpha = \pm 1$ forces $\alpha = 1$, giving $p_0 = (1, 0)$, $q_0 = (k, 1)$. If $\beta = 1$ then $\det(p_0, q_0) = -(k+1-\alpha) = \pm 1$ forces $\alpha = k$, giving the same pair with the roles swapped. $\square$

By Lemma 2.2 we may and do *normalize the labels* so that $p_0 = (1, 0)$ and $q_0 = (k, 1)$; if the corner $(k, 1)$ belongs to P instead, replace (P, Q) by $(Q, -P)$, which has the same bracket and swaps the roles. (This relabeling matters: an early version of the theory phrased the gap condition below asymmetrically in Q and was corrected by review; the obstruction is side-symmetric.) The widths are then determined: $w_P = w(1, 0) = d_2$ and $w_Q = w(k, 1) = kd_2 - 1$.

Each full strip column is a ladder of consecutive lattice points: column $x = c$ of P is $\{(c, j) : d_2c - w_P \leq j \leq d_2c\}$, and likewise for Q , so at type (k, d_2) a full P -column has $d_2 + 1$ points and a full Q -column has kd_2 points.

The gap condition. The second hypothesis is a single inequality:

(ii) (*gap condition*) $k \geq 2$; equivalently, by Lemma 2.2, $\max((p_0)_x, (q_0)_x) \geq 2$.

Its meaning: when $k \geq 2$, the polygon Q has support columns $x = 1, \dots, k - 1$ strictly between the y -axis and the column of its bottom corner. Because the bottom edge of $N(Q)$ runs from $(0, 0)$ to $(k, 1)$, the points of such a *gap column* $x = g$ are (g, y) with $1 \leq y \leq d_2g$: they hover strictly above the bottom edge. These columns produce bracket keys below and to the left of the vertex $(k + 1, 1)$, and Section 3 shows that they are forced to vanish, which is the engine of the obstruction. When $k = 1$ there is no gap column on either side, and no such forcing exists. Under (i), the conditions “ $k \geq 2$ ” and “a gap column exists on exactly one side” are the same condition; no strip pair can separate them.

3 The gap condition and the counting theorem

We now assume (i) and (ii) in the normalized labels: $p_0 = (1, 0)$, $q_0 = (k, 1)$, $w_P = d_2$, $w_Q = kd_2 - 1$, and a_{p_0} , b_{q_0} units. The plan: first the gap columns die; then a small block of keys near the origin becomes a self-contained linear system in the nearby coefficients; counting its equations against its unknowns explains, and in favorable cells proves, the collapse.

Lemma 3.1 (gap kill). *On the solution set, every coefficient of Q in the gap columns $x = 1, \dots, k - 1$ vanishes.*

Proof. Induct on the column g and, inside a column, on the level ℓ . Let (g, y) be a gap point, so $1 \leq y \leq d_2g$. The key at the sub-vertex Minkowski point $p_0 + (g, y) = (1 + g, y)$ contains the monomial $\det(p_0, (g, y)) a_{p_0} b_{(g, y)} = y a_{p_0} b_{(g, y)}$ with $y \geq 1$. Any other pair (p', q') with $p' + q' = (1 + g, y)$ either has q' the origin (then $\det(p', q') = 0$) or has p' in a P -column $x \geq 1$, hence q' in a gap column $\leq g$ with either smaller column or smaller level than (g, y) ; by induction $b_{q'} = 0$. So the key reduces to a single monomial with unit cofactor a_{p_0} and nonzero constant y , forcing $b_{(g, y)} = 0$. (This uses that y is invertible: $1 \leq y \leq d_2(k - 1)$, a first source of excluded small primes.) $\square$

In the (8, 28) example the gap column is $x = 1$ of Q , with points $(1, 1)$, $(1, 2)$; the sub-vertex keys $E_{(2, 1)} = a_{p_0} b_{(1, 1)}$ and $E_{(2, 2)} = 2a_{p_0} b_{(1, 2)}$ kill it. Note the mechanism needs the absence of y -axis support (S3): a P -coefficient at $(0, a)$ would contribute $\det((0, a), (g', b)) \neq 0$ terms to the same keys, and the forcing fails. This is precisely why the pentagon-shaped subcase (1) of [7] is outside the theory (Section 7).

The near-origin block. Define the *block* to be the set of keys in Minkowski columns $k + 1$ and $k + 2$. After the gap kill, a pair (p, q) with $a_p b_q$ alive can land in the block only with p in P -column 1 or 2 and q in Q -column k or $k + 1$: the origin pairs have $\det = 0$, gap columns are dead, and larger P -columns would push q into a dead or negative column. Conversely such pairs land only in the block. So the block is *self-contained*: its equations involve exactly the coefficients in P -columns 1, 2 and Q -columns $k, k + 1$, no matter how long the strips are. All counting can be done locally, and the block has fixed size depending only on (k, d_2) .

Proposition 3.2 (key count). *For all $k, d_2 \geq 1$, the number of forced-to-vanish block keys that are not identically zero is $n_{\text{keys}} = 2(w_P + w_Q) - 1$.*

Proof. Column $k + 1$ of $N(P) + N(Q)$ is the ladder $(k + 1, y)$, $1 \leq y \leq d_2(k + 1)$, i.e. strata $w = 0, \dots, w_P + w_Q$; the vertex $(k + 1, 1)$ is the bottom stratum $w = w_P + w_Q$. The stratum $w = 0$ is identically zero: $w(p) + w(q) = 0$ with both weights ≥ 0 forces $w(p) = w(q) = 0$, so $p, q \in \mathbb{R}d$ and $\det(p, q) = 0$. Every stratum $1 \leq w \leq w_P + w_Q$ genuinely occurs after the gap kill: for $w \geq w_P$ take the pair (p_0, q) with q in the full Q -column k at weight $w - w_P$, whose determinant is $q_2 \geq 1$; for $1 \leq w \leq w_P - 1$ take $p = (1, d_2 - w)$ in P -column 1 and $q = (k, kd_2)$ the top of Q -column k , with $\det(p, q) = kw \neq 0$. Distinct pairs give distinct monomials $a_p b_q$, so no cancellation occurs and each such key is a genuine equation. Removing the vertex key leaves $w_P + w_Q - 1$ keys. Column $k + 2$ is the same ladder argument with bottom point $(k + 2, 1 + d_2)$ on the long Minkowski edge (witnesses: (p_0, q) with q in column $k + 1$, and $p = (1, d_2 - w)$ against the top of column $k + 1$, $\det = (k + 1)w$); there is no vertex to remove, giving $w_P + w_Q$ keys. Total $2(w_P + w_Q) - 1$. $\square$

Proposition 3.3 (eliminations and extra keys). *All $2w_Q + 1$ non-corner coefficients b_q with q in Q -columns k and $k + 1$ are eliminable by unit pivots, each from its own key at $m = p_0 + q$; this consumes exactly the block keys of strata $w_P \leq w \leq w_P + w_Q$ (vertex excluded). The remaining extra keys are the $2(w_P - 1)$ keys of strata $1 \leq w \leq w_P - 1$ in the two block columns.*

Proof. The key at $p_0 + q$ contains $\det(p_0, q) a_{p_0} b_q = q_2 a_{p_0} b_q$ with $q_2 \geq 1$ and unit cofactor a_{p_0} , and this is the only monomial of that key containing b_q (the pair with second factor q is unique). The map $q \mapsto p_0 + q$ is injective, hits exactly the strata $w(p_0 + q) = w_P + w(q) \in [w_P, w_P + w_Q]$ in each block column, and misses only the vertex ($q = q_0$). Triangularity: in any other monomial (p', q') of the key at $p_0 + q$ one has $\ell(p') > \ell(p_0)$ (a point of P -column 1 other than p_0 has $\ell = d_2 + j > d_2$, and column 2 has $\ell \geq 2d_2$), hence $\ell(q') < \ell(q)$, so eliminating in increasing level of q is well founded and each substitution inserts only already-expressed or lower-level variables. The counts follow: $2w_Q + 1$ keys consumed (a full Q -column has $kd_2 = w_Q + 1$ points, two columns minus the corner), and $n_{\text{keys}} - (2w_Q + 1) = 2(w_P - 1)$ extra keys, precisely the strata $1 \leq w \leq w_P - 1$. $\square$

Propositions 3.2 and 3.3 hold for every $k, d_2 \geq 1$ (characteristic caveat: the integer determinants used as pivots must be invertible). The content of the extra keys, after back-substituting the eliminated b 's, is what varies from cell to cell. We say an extra key is of *pinning type* (PINS) if its back-substituted form is $(\text{unit}) \cdot M \cdot b_{q_0}$ with M a nonzero monomial in the P -coefficients: such a key pins the corner unit b_{q_0} to zero on the chart where M is invertible, contradicting the vertex equation. The main theorem says this happens at $(k, d_2) = (2, 2)$, with $M = a_2^2 a_6$.

Theorem 3.4 (vertex-gap obstruction, $(k, d_2) = (2, 2)$). *Let (P, Q) be a reduced strip pair of type $(2, 2)$ satisfying (i), with strips of any lengths containing the block columns, over a field of characteristic not in $\{2, 3, 5\}$. Write*

$$a_1 = a_{(1,0)}, a_2 = a_{(1,1)}, a_3 = a_{(1,2)}, a_4 = a_{(2,2)}, a_5 = a_{(2,3)}, a_6 = a_{(2,4)}$$

for the block P -coefficients (a_1 a unit) and $b_3 = b_{(2,1)}$ (a unit), $b_4 = b_{(2,2)}$, $b_5 = b_{(2,3)}$, $b_6 = b_{(2,4)}$, $b_7 = b_{(3,3)}$, $\dots$, $b_{10} = b_{(3,6)}$ for the block Q -coefficients. Then every solution satisfies $a_3 = 0$ and $a_2^2 a_6 = 0$. In particular the locus $a_2 a_6 \neq 0$ is empty, and the block variety is contained in $\{a_3 = 0\} \cap (\{a_2 = 0\} \cup \{a_6 = 0\})$.

Proof. Here $w_P = 2$, $w_Q = 3$, $p_0 = (1, 0)$, $q_0 = (2, 1)$; by Proposition 3.2 there are 9 block keys besides the vertex, and by Proposition 3.3 seven of them eliminate $b_4, \dots, b_{10}$. After the gap kill ($b_{(1,1)} = b_{(1,2)} = 0$), the nine keys, in elimination order, reduce as follows (each line lists the Minkowski point, the key, and its consequence after substituting the previous lines):

$$\begin{array}{lll}
(3, 2) : & 2a_1b_4 - a_2b_3 = 0 & \Rightarrow b_4 = \frac{a_2b_3}{2a_1} \\
(3, 3) : & 3a_1b_5 - 3a_3b_3 = 0 & \Rightarrow b_5 = \frac{a_3b_3}{a_1} \\
(3, 4) : & 4a_1b_6 + a_2b_5 - 2a_3b_4 = 0 & \Rightarrow b_6 = 0 \quad [\text{C1}] \\
(3, 5) : & 2a_2b_6 - a_3b_5 = 0 & \Rightarrow -\frac{a_3^2b_3}{a_1} = 0 \Rightarrow a_3 = 0 \\
(4, 3) : & 3a_1b_7 - 2a_4b_3 = 0 & \Rightarrow b_7 = \frac{2a_4b_3}{3a_1} \\
(4, 4) : & 4a_1b_8 - 4a_5b_3 = 0 & \Rightarrow b_8 = \frac{a_5b_3}{a_1} \\
(4, 5) : & 5a_1b_9 + a_2b_8 - 3a_3b_7 + 2a_4b_5 - 2a_5b_4 - 6a_6b_3 = 0 & \Rightarrow b_9 = \frac{6a_6b_3}{5a_1} \quad [\text{C2}] \\
(4, 6) : & 6a_1b_{10} + 2a_2b_9 - 2a_3b_8 + 4a_4b_6 - 4a_6b_4 = 0 & \Rightarrow b_{10} = -\frac{a_2a_6b_3}{15a_1^2} \\
(4, 7) : & 3a_2b_{10} - a_3b_9 + 2a_5b_6 - 2a_6b_5 = 0 & \Rightarrow -\frac{1}{5} \frac{a_2^2a_6b_3}{a_1^2} = 0.
\end{array}$$

Two exact cancellations create the surplus. In (3, 4), substituting b_5 and b_4 gives $a_2b_5 - 2a_3b_4 = \frac{a_2a_3b_3}{a_1} - \frac{a_2a_3b_3}{a_1} = 0$, so $b_6 = 0$ [C1]. In (4, 5), the pairs $-3a_3b_7 + 2a_4b_5$ and $a_2b_8 - 2a_5b_4$ cancel identically (both differences vanish even before $a_3 = 0$), leaving b_9 proportional to a_6 alone [C2]. The key (3, 5) then carries a single monomial $-a_3^2b_3/a_1$ with unit cofactors, forcing $a_3 = 0$ on the solution set; this is the one forced P -side vanishing. The final line is the surplus key: nine equations against eight eliminable unknowns ($b_4, \dots, b_{10}$ and a_3). Its back-substituted form is of pinning type with $M = a_2^2a_6$, so $a_2^2a_6b_3 = 0$; since b_3 is a unit by the vertex equation, $a_2^2a_6 = 0$. The pivot constants used are $\{2, 3, 4, 3, 4, 5, 6\}$, the gap pivots $\{1, 2\}$, and the final $1/5$: characteristic outside $\{2, 3, 5\}$ suffices. $\square$

Remark 3.5 (radical, not ideal, membership). The step $a_3 = 0$ is extracted from the relation $a_3^2b_3/a_1 = 0$, which is quadratic in a_3 . Consequently the chart-free form of the conclusion is a *radical* membership: $u := a_2^2a_6b_{q_0}$ satisfies $u^2 \in I$, where I is the ideal generated by the block, gap and vertex equations, but $u \notin I$. A witness over the dual numbers $K[\varepsilon]/(\varepsilon^2)$: set $a_3 = \varepsilon$, $a_2 = 1$, $a_6 = \varepsilon c$; all generators of I can be satisfied while $u = \varepsilon c b_{q_0} \neq 0$. Every variety-level statement in Theorem 3.4 is unaffected. (An earlier internal write-up claimed ideal membership; adversarial review produced this counterexample, and we record the corrected statement.)

Remark 3.6 (position of the surplus key). In the general labels, the surplus key is the topmost non-vanishing key of the *outer* block column: stratum $w = 1$ of Minkowski column $k + 2$, i.e.

$$m_{\text{surplus}} = (k + 2, d_2(k + 2) - 1),$$

which at (2, 2) is (4, 7). The $w = 1$ key of the inner column, $(k + 1, d_2(k + 1) - 1) = (3, 5)$, is not the surplus: it is the rigidity event that forces $a_3 = 0$. Distinguishing the two matters; a bare count of equations minus unknowns equals 1 even in cells where no obstruction exists (see Section 4), so it is the pinning-type *content* of the surplus key, not the count, that discriminates.

Remark 3.7 (excluded primes). The set $\{2, 3, 5\}$ is exactly the set of primes dividing some constant used by this derivation, and each of 2, 3, 5 genuinely occurs, so the set is sharp for the proof. It appears to be proof-technical rather than intrinsic: exact rank computations at

random points indicate the obstruction persists modulo 2, 3 and 5 as well. We make no claim in those characteristics.

4 Variant exponents and an impossibility result

What happens outside $(2, 2)$? By Proposition 3.3 the block has $2(w_P - 1) = 2(d_2 - 1)$ extra keys, so the single-surplus picture is special to $d_2 = 2$. To compute the extra keys uniformly we assemble each strip column into a generating polynomial. Write

$$A(y) = \sum_{i=0}^{d_2} a_{(1,i)} y^i, \quad B(y) = \sum_{j=d_2}^{2d_2} \beta_j y^j \quad (\beta_j := a_{(2,j)}), \quad C(y) = \sum_{j=1}^{kd_2} b_{(k,j)} y^j, \quad E(y) = \sum_{j=d_2+1}^{(k+1)d_2} b_{(k+1,j)} y^j$$

for P -columns $1, 2$ and Q -columns $k, k+1$. From $\det((1, i), (k, j)) = j - ik$ and $\det((2, i), (k, j)) = 2j - ik$ one checks directly that the block keys are the coefficients of

$$\text{column } k+1 : AC' - kA'C, \quad \text{column } k+2 : AE' - (k+1)A'E + 2BC' - kB'C, \quad (2)$$

the key at Minkowski point $(k+1, s)$ resp. $(k+2, s)$ being the coefficient of y^{s-1} , and the vertex equation the constant term $a_{p_0} b_{q_0}$ of the first expression. (This assembly is machine-checked against an independent lattice-determinant enumeration of every block key; the two agree exactly at all computed cells.) Proposition 3.3 solves the lower coefficients of these two linear ODE-like relations for C and E ; the extra keys are the would-be next coefficients of the solved series. To declutter we normalize the units $a_{p_0} = b_{q_0} = 1$ in this section; unit factors are restored routinely.

4.1 Type $(2, 3)$: support rigidity plus one hyperplane

At $(k, d_2) = (2, 3)$ we have $A = 1 + a_2 y + a_3 y^2 + a_4 y^3$, $B = \beta_3 y^3 + \dots + \beta_6 y^6$, and there are four extra keys: the inner pair L_1, L_2 (Minkowski $(3, 7), (3, 8)$, the coefficients of y^6, y^7 in $AC' - 2A'C$) and the outer pair L_3, L_4 $((4, 10), (4, 11))$. Back-substitution gives the exact forms

$$\begin{aligned} 10L_1 &= 2a_3^3 - 4a_2^2 a_3^2 + 2a_2^3 a_4 + 19a_2 a_3 a_4 - 25a_4^2, \\ 10L_2 &= -2a_2 a_3^3 + a_2^2 a_3 a_4 + 8a_3^2 a_4 + a_2 a_4^2, \end{aligned}$$

while L_3, L_4 are longer (18 monomials each), linear in $\beta_3, \dots, \beta_6$. Note L_1, L_2 involve only the P -column A : no pinning of b_{q_0} is available here, and on the computed grid no extra key at $d_2 \geq 3$ ever reduces to a single monomial. Instead the inner pair forces a support degeneration.

Theorem 4.1 (rigidity at $(2, 3)$). *Over a field of characteristic not in $\{2, 3, 5\}$, $V(L_1, L_2) = \{a_3 = a_4 = 0\}$: the inner extra keys force $A = 1 + a_2 y$, a binomial.*

Proof 1 (resultant certificate). $\text{Res}_{a_4}(10L_1, 10L_2) = -3200 a_3^7$, and the leading coefficient of $10L_1$ in a_4 is the constant -25 , so for every fixed (a_2, a_3) the two polynomials have a common root in a_4 only if the resultant vanishes: any common zero has $a_3 = 0$. On that slice $10L_2 = a_2 a_4^2$ and $10L_1 = 2a_2^3 a_4 - 25a_4^2$; if $a_4 \neq 0$ the first forces $a_2 = 0$ and then the second reads $-25a_4^2 \neq 0$. So $a_4 = 0$. Conversely $a_3 = a_4 = 0$ kills every monomial. $\square$

Proof 2 (structural). The inner extras vanish exactly when the column identity $C'A - 2A'C = 1$ holds as polynomials, with C the solved column of degree ≤ 6 . At a root r of A of multiplicity

≥ 2 the left side is divisible by $y - r$ while the right side is 1: so A is squarefree, and at each simple root $-2A'(r)C(r) = 1$, whence $A'(r), C(r) \neq 0$. Differentiating the identity twice and evaluating at r yields $3A''(r)^2 = A'(r)A'''(r)$, i.e. A divides $N(A) := 3A''^2 - A'A'''$. If $\deg A = 3$ then $N = (12a_3^2 - 6a_2a_4) + 60a_3a_4y + 90a_4^2y^2$ has degree < 3 , so divisibility forces $N = 0$, but its top coefficient $90a_4^2$ is nonzero. If $\deg A = 2$ then $N = 12a_3^2$ is a nonzero constant. Hence $\deg A \leq 1$. $\square$

Theorem 4.2 (complete block variety at $(2, 3)$). *On the locus $a_3 = a_4 = 0$ one has $L_4 \equiv 0$ identically and $L_3 = \frac{a_2^3}{21} R$, where*

$$R = a_2^2\beta_4 - 5a_2\beta_5 + 15\beta_6.$$

Hence $V(L_1, L_2, L_3, L_4) = \{a_3 = a_4 = 0, a_2 = 0\} \cup \{a_3 = a_4 = 0, R = 0\}$, and in particular the block variety contains no point with all block coordinates nonzero. The inner (rigidity) part uses only characteristics outside $\{2, 3, 5\}$; the outer computation excludes primes in $\{2, 3, 5, 7, 11\}$.

The coefficients 1, -5 , 15 are $(-1)^j \binom{j}{4}$ for $j = 4, 5, 6$; Section 6 explains where they come from. Two honest contrasts with Theorem 3.4. First, the forced content here is *support rigidity*: $a_3 = a_4 = 0$ are interior (non-corner) coefficients, so hypothesis (i) is untouched and no contradiction with the vertex equation arises. Second, there is no pinning: b_{q_0} remains free, and on the main component $a_2 \neq 0$ the residual condition $R = 0$ is a three-term linear form in $\beta_4, \beta_5, \beta_6$, satisfiable with every coordinate nonzero. The $(2, 2)$ single-monomial collapse is genuinely special.

4.2 Type $(2, 4)$, and certificates at $(3, 3)$, $(4, 3)$, $(5, 3)$

Theorem 4.3 (rigidity and block variety at $(2, 4)$). *Let $(k, d_2) = (2, 4)$, $A = 1 + py + qy^2 + ry^3 + sy^4$, over characteristic 0 (the proof excludes only primes in $\{2, 3, 5, 7\}$ for the rigidity part, plus 11 for the outer part). The three inner extras force $q = r = s = 0$, so A is again a binomial; on that locus two of the three outer extras vanish identically and the third equals $-\frac{p^4}{55}R_4$ with*

$$R_4 = p^4\beta_4 - 5p^3\beta_5 + 15p^2\beta_6 - 35p\beta_7 + 70\beta_8.$$

Hence $V(\text{all six extras}) = \{q = r = s = 0, p = 0\} \cup \{q = r = s = 0, R_4 = 0\}$, and torus-emptiness persists.

Proof of the rigidity part. As in Theorem 4.1, the inner extras vanish iff $C'A - 2A'C = 1$ exactly, forcing A squarefree and $A \mid N(A) = 3A''^2 - A'A'''$. Compute $N - 336sA = E_0 + 60E_1y + 30E_2y^2$ (the top two coefficients cancel), where $E_0 = 12q^2 - 6pr - 336s$, $E_1 = qr - 6ps$, $E_2 = 3r^2 - 8qs$. If $\deg A = 4$ ($s \neq 0$), divisibility of the degree- ≤ 2 remainder by A forces $E_0 = E_1 = E_2 = 0$; the identities

$$9sE_0 = 84s(q^2 - 36s) - 3qE_2 + 9rE_1, \quad 27r^2 - 2q^3 = 9E_2 - 2q(q^2 - 36s)$$

then give $q^2 = 36s$ and $27r^2 = 2q^3$, and $E_1 = 0$ with $q \neq 0$ gives $r = pq/6$; these force $(p, q, r, s) = (4u, 6u^2, 4u^3, u^4)$, i.e. $A = (1 + uy)^4$ with $u \neq 0$, which is not squarefree: contradiction. The cases $\deg A = 3, 2$ are as before. Hence $\deg A \leq 1$. $\square$

Remark 4.4. Every perfect power $(1 + uy)^\delta$ with $\delta \geq 4$ satisfies the divisibility $A \mid N(A)$; it is squarefreeness that eliminates it. Any proof for general d_2 must keep both halves of the argument, which is why we do not yet have one (see the conjecture in Section 6).

Theorem 4.5 (rigidity certificates at $(k, 3)$, $k = 3, 4, 5$). *At $(k, d_2) = (3, 3), (4, 3), (5, 3)$ the inner extra keys again force $a_3 = a_4 = 0$ (A binomial); consequently these block varieties contain no point with all block coordinates nonzero. The proof is a machine-verified pair of exact Sylvester resultant computations for each cell: an a_4 -resultant of two inner extras equal to ca_3^m with constant a_4 -leading coefficient, followed by an a_2 -resultant on the slice $a_3 = 0$ equal to $c'a_4^N$; the exponents (m, N) are $(15, 12), (26, 34), (40, 44)$ respectively. The certificates are exact rational arithmetic, assertion-locked in the repository (Section 8).*

We state Theorem 4.5 as certified computation rather than conceptual proof: unlike Theorems 4.1 and 4.3 we have no structural derivation at these cells, and rigidity at $(3, 4), (4, 4), (5, 4)$ and $d_2 \geq 5$ is open.

4.3 Impossibility for $k \geq 3$ at $d_2 = 2$

The gap condition (ii) holds for every $k \geq 2$, so one might hope the $(2, 2)$ collapse generalizes in k . It provably does not.

Theorem 4.6 (no near-origin obstruction, $k \geq 3$, $d_2 = 2$). *Fix $k \geq 3$ and $d_2 = 2$, over a field of characteristic 0 or $> 2k + 3$. For arbitrary values of a_2 and of $\beta_2, \beta_3, \beta_4$ (the column B), with $a_3 := 0$, the columns*

$$C = \frac{1}{ka_2} [(1 + a_2 y)^k - 1] \quad (\text{and } C = y \text{ if } a_2 = 0), \quad E = E(a_2, \beta_\bullet; y) \text{ as below,}$$

satisfy every key of the depth-two block. Consequently no extra key of pinning type exists, no chart in the coordinates $(a_2, \beta_2, \beta_3, \beta_4)$ is emptied, and the only near-origin restriction on P is the support condition $a_3 = 0$.

Proof sketch. The column- $(k+1)$ relation $AC' - kA'C = 1$ has the one-dimensional solution family $C = A^k(\kappa + \int_0^y A^{-(k+1)})$, and the valuation ≥ 1 forces $\kappa = 0$. The inner extra key is the would-be next series coefficient of this C ; its vanishing locus contains $\{a_3 = 0\}$, since with $A = 1 + a_2 y$ the series truncates: C is the stated polynomial of degree k , fitting Q -column k . For column $k+2$, substitute $z = 1 + a_2 y$ and $\beta(z) := B(y(z))$ (a polynomial of z -degree $4 = 2d_2$ with $\beta(1) = 0$); the relation $AE' - (k+1)A'E = -(2BC' - kB'C)$ integrates to

$$E = -\frac{1}{a_2} z^{k+1} \int_1^z [2\beta w^{-3} - \beta' w^{-2} + \beta' w^{-(k+2)}] dw.$$

The first two integrand terms are exact, $2\beta w^{-3} - \beta' w^{-2} = -\frac{d}{dw}(\beta w^{-2})$, and the third integrates to $\sum_m \beta'_m \frac{z^{m-k-1}-1}{m-k-1}$, which is polynomial in z provided no index m equals $k+1$. Since $\deg_z \beta' = 2d_2 - 1 = 3 < k+1$ for $k \geq 3$, this always holds: E is a polynomial of degree $\leq k+3 \leq 2k+2$, fits Q -column $k+1$, and every key of column $k+2$, including both extras, holds identically. The case $a_2 = 0$ is direct. Every coefficient identity in this argument is additionally machine-checked for $k \leq 10$. $\square$

Two honest limitations. First, the theorem concerns the depth-two block only: deeper Minkowski columns add one leftover key per column, each a residue-type linear condition on the fresh P -column, and numerical probes suggest these are satisfiable, but we have not proved it. Second, the sharp form of the inner extra key, namely that it reduces to exactly $-a_3^k b_{q_0} a_1^{1-k}$ (so that its vanishing locus is exactly $\{a_3 = 0\}$ by radicality), is verified by exact computation for $k \leq 10$ but not closed for general k ; the containment used above is proved for all k .

5 A worked example: the (8, 28) chart

We now replay the computation that started everything, in its original coordinates. Proposition 4.3, subcase (2), of [7] asks for pairs with $[P, Q] = x^2$,

$$N(P) = \text{hull}\{(0, 0), (1, 0), (8, 14), (8, 16)\}, \quad N(Q) = \text{hull}\{(0, 0), (2, 1), (12, 21), (12, 24)\},$$

and the listed vertices attained. This is a reduced strip pair of type (2, 2): $d = (1, 2)$, $p_0 = (1, 0)$, $q_0 = (2, 1)$, strips of lengths 8 and 12 columns. The bracket system has 92 keys (Minkowski points whose coefficient is not identically zero); in the repository's ordering (sorted by monomial) the vertex key $E_{(3,1)}$, the coefficient of the right-hand monomial x^2 itself, is equation #3, and reads

$$a_1 b_3 - 1 = 0$$

by uniqueness of the decomposition $(3, 1) = (1, 0) + (2, 1)$ with $\det = 1$. Here, as in Theorem 3.4, $a_1 = a_{(1,0)}$ and $b_3 = b_{(2,1)}$.

The pipeline (Section 8) runs a level-ordered elimination: after the gap kill $b_{(1,1)} = b_{(1,2)} = 0$, it performs 41 unit-pivot eliminations expressing the Q -coefficients of columns $x = 12$ down to $x = 2$ in P -data, pivoting on the far top corners for the far columns and on a_1 near the origin, and then passes to the generic chart. Because equation #3 contains only the unit variables a_1, b_3 , no step of the cascade ever touches it: it passes through verbatim. The entire collapse is carried by one other equation, the key at Minkowski point (4, 7) (artifact key (3, 6)), which in the full-length strips reads

$$E_{(4,7)} = 3a_2 b_{10} - a_3 b_9 + 2a_5 b_6 - 2a_6 b_5 + a_{(3,5)} b_{(1,2)} - 3a_{(3,6)} b_{(1,1)}.$$

Exactly ten recorded events touch it, and they are exactly the block-local reduction of Theorem 3.4 plus the gap kill:

- 1–2. $b_{(1,1)} := 0$ and $b_{(1,2)} := 0$ (gap kill; removes the last two monomials);
- 3–6. eliminations of b_{10}, b_9, b_8, b_7 from the keys (4, 6), (4, 5), (4, 4), (4, 3);
- 7–9. eliminations of b_6, b_5, b_4 from the keys (3, 4), (3, 3), (3, 2);
- 10. $a_3 := 0$ (from the reduced key (3, 5)).

After event 10 the equation is the single monomial

$$-\frac{1}{5} a_2^2 a_6 b_3 a_1^{-2} = 0.$$

On the generic chart this coefficient is invertible, so the chart substitutes $b_3 := 0$; feeding this into the untouched equation #3 gives

$$a_1 \cdot 0 - 1 = -1,$$

and the chart is empty. The -1 is literally the transcription of the right-hand side $-x^2$; no other arithmetic touches it. A full symbolic census after cascade and chart: of the 92 original equations, 51 reduce to 0, 40 remain polynomial, and equation #3 is the unique constant. The complete chain uses pivot constants whose prime support is exactly $\{2, 3, 5, 7, 11, 13\}$ (the far-column pivots contribute 7, 11, 13; the obstruction itself, as in Theorem 3.4, needs only $\{2, 3, 5\}$), so the derivation is valid over characteristic 0 and over $\mathbb{F}_p$ for $p \notin \{2, 3, 5, 7, 11, 13\}$.

Remark 5.1 (The characteristic restrictions are necessary). The characteristic restrictions in our results are not an artifact of the method. Mondello’s plane Keller pair $P = x + x^2y + x^4 + x^6y^2$, $Q = y + x^5 + x^6y + x^7y^2 + x^8y^3$ over $\mathbb{F}_2$ [12] has Jacobian determinant 1, sends the three distinct points $(0, 1)$, $(1, 0)$, $(1, 1)$ to a common image, and generates a degree 3 separable field extension, so even the separable Jacobian conjecture fails in characteristic two. Its Newton polygons form a strip pair along the direction $(1, 1)$ satisfying our vertex normalization, and in any characteristic other than two our near-origin eliminations, whose pivot constants at this polygon data are the lattice determinants 2, 4, and 6, force the strip corners to vanish and reduce any such pair to an elementary automorphism. In characteristic two every one of these determinants vanishes, the corresponding bracket equations become identically zero, and the strips survive; this is precisely the escape that Mondello’s example exploits. (We verified the example by direct bracket computation; it lies in the cell $(k, d_2) = (0, 1)$, outside the regime of Theorem 3.4, so there is no tension with our characteristic zero statements.)

Chart-free restatement, in the language of Section 3: $(\text{unit}) \cdot a_2^2 a_6 \cdot b_3$ lies in the radical of the system’s ideal, so with the vertex equation (b_3 a unit) every solution has $a_2^2 a_6 = 0$, and the solution variety splits as $\{a_2 = 0\} \cup \{a_6 = 0\}$. This *derives*, rather than guesses, the two-branch case split under which the remaining (non-generic) strata were handed to Gröbner engines in the computational discard, and it is where the 10-event chain first suggested the general mechanism: the tower of bracket relations near the origin is overdetermined by exactly one equation once the gap column dies, and the surplus relation pins the bottom corner of Q against the vertex normalization.

Every item in this section is re-runnable: the chain is recorded with per-equation provenance and was replayed by an adversarial review with independently written geometry, substitution and census code, which also verified determinism (no pivot ties) and spot-checked the derivation at fresh random rational points. The two central identities of the chain are additionally machine-checked in Lean 4 with mathlib: the reduction of the key- $(3, 6)$ coefficient under the ten recorded substitutions to $(-1/5) a_2^2 a_6 \iota_{a_1}^2 b_3$ (where ι_{a_1} denotes the formal inverse of a_1), and the collapse of equation #3 to -1 at $b_3 = 0$. The Lean proof of the first identity holds already in the free commutative ring, without consuming the unit relations, and therefore specializes to the localization used here. The formal development, its axiom audit, and its honest scope (the identity chain only, not the census and not the variety preservation of the eliminations) are part of the artifact repository.

6 The log-residue functional: a conjecture

The integral formula in the proof of Theorem 4.6 explains all the coefficients seen so far, and suggests the general picture. Work on the binomial locus ($A = 1 + a_2 y$ after normalizing units, $a_2 \neq 0$) at any type (k, d_2) , and substitute $z = 1 + a_2 y$, $\beta(z) := B(y(z))$, a polynomial of z -degree $2d_2$ with $\beta(1) = 0$. The solved outer column is

$$E = -\frac{1}{a_2} z^{k+1} \int_1^z \left[2\beta w^{-3} - \beta' w^{-2} + \beta' w^{-(k+2)} \right] dw,$$

and the only term that can obstruct polynomiality is the index $m = k + 1$ in $\beta' = \sum_m \beta'_m w^m$: it integrates to $\beta'_{k+1} \log z$. Since $\deg_z \beta' = 2d_2 - 1$, such a term exists precisely when

$$k + 1 \leq 2d_2 - 1.$$

When it exists, the solved column E acquires the tail $-\frac{1}{a_2}\beta'_{k+1}z^{k+1}\log z$, whose truncated coefficients are what the extra keys see: the near-origin geometry obstructs exactly when the logarithmic residue β'_{k+1} survives. Expanding β through $y = (z-1)/a_2$ gives, up to an explicit unit times a power of a_2 ,

$$\beta'_{k+1} \doteq R_{k,d_2} := \sum_{j=k+2}^{2d_2} (-1)^j \binom{j}{k+2} a_2^{2d_2-j} \beta_j,$$

a linear form in the P -column-2 coefficients $\beta_j = a_{(2,j)}$ with binomial coefficients. This one functional organizes every cell computed so far:

- $(2,2)$: the sum has the single term $j=4$: $R_{2,2} = \beta_4 = a_6$. The pinning monomial $a_2^2 a_6$ of Theorem 3.4 is $a_2^2 R_{2,2}$: the PINS obstruction is the one-term case of the residue.
- $(k,2)$, $k \geq 3$: the sum is empty, $R \equiv 0$, and Theorem 4.6 confirms that no obstruction exists.
- $(2,3)$ and $(2,4)$: $R_{2,3} = a_2^2 \beta_4 - 5a_2 \beta_5 + 15\beta_6$ and $R_{2,4} = a_2^4 \beta_4 - 5a_2^3 \beta_5 + 15a_2^2 \beta_6 - 35a_2 \beta_7 + 70\beta_8$, exactly the hyperplanes of Theorems 4.2 and 4.3.
- On the binomial locus, in every computed cell exactly one outer extra key survives and equals a unit times a power of a_2 times R_{k,d_2} , the other outer extras vanishing identically there; the verified unit factors are $\frac{a_2^3}{21}$ at $(2,3)$, $-\frac{a_2^6}{99}$ at $(3,3)$, $\frac{2a_2^9}{1001}$ at $(4,3)$, $-\frac{a_2^4}{55}$ at $(2,4)$, $-\frac{a_2^8}{364}$ at $(3,4)$; at $(5,3)$, where $k+2 > 2d_2$, every outer extra vanishes identically, as the empty sum predicts.

Conjecture 6.1 (log-residue description of the block variety). *For every $k \geq 2$, $d_2 \geq 2$, and every reduced strip pair of type (k, d_2) satisfying (i), the variety of the extra keys of the depth-two block is*

$$V(\text{extras}) = \{A \text{ binomial}\} \cap (\{a_2 = 0\} \cup \{R_{k,d_2} = 0\}),$$

where “ A binomial” means $a_{(1,i)} = 0$ for $2 \leq i \leq d_2$.

If true, the conjecture implies: torus-emptiness of the block at every cell with $k, d_2 \geq 2$ (via the forced $a_{(1,2)} = 0$); a pinning-type obstruction exactly at $(k, d_2) = (2, 2)$, where R is a single monomial; no b -side obstruction for $d_2 \geq 3$ (R is then a multi-term linear form, satisfiable on the torus); and no residue condition at all when $k > 2d_2 - 2$. Current status: proved at $(2, 2)$, $(2, 3)$, $(2, 4)$ (Theorems 3.4, 4.2, 4.3); at $(3, 3)$, $(4, 3)$, $(5, 3)$ the rigidity half is certified and the outer identity has been verified by exact symbolic computation, so the description is confirmed there by certificate; open at $(3, 4)$, $(4, 4)$, $(5, 4)$ and for all $d_2 \geq 5$, where the perfect-power component of the divisibility argument (Remark after Theorem 4.3) is the obstacle. The conjecture says nothing about Minkowski columns beyond $k+2$; each deeper column contributes one further residue-type condition, and their joint behavior is unexplored.

7 Application: GGV coverage at $(72, 108)$

How much of the GGV landscape does this theory touch? Section 7 of [6] tabulates all 34 admissible corner families with $\max(\deg P, \deg Q) \leq 150$. For each family the type data of

a hypothetical strip reduction is pure corner arithmetic: for family corner $A_0 = (a, b)$ with $b > a$, the right-hand exponent is $k = \lceil b/a \rceil - 2$, and if b/a is not an integer the strip slope is $d_2 = a/(\lceil b/a \rceil a - b)$. If b/a is an integer, the A_0 -corner maps onto the y -axis under the reduction, so any subcase keeping that corner has y -axis support and is outside Definition 2.1 (the gap-kill mechanism fails there, as noted after Lemma 3.1). Classifying the 34 rows:

class	rows	basis
theorem-covered	1	(8, 28): strip subcase in the proved (2, 2) cell (partial)
mechanism-absent, $k = 1$	19	no gap column; condition (ii) fails identically
mechanism-absent, $k \geq 3$	4	conditional (see text)
discarded	1	(8, 32): not a possible pair at all [7]
unknown	9	$k = 2$ rows, case-by-case reduction not carried out

Honest annotations. The single theorem-covered row is covered *partially*: the (8, 28) family reduces in [7] to two subcases, and only subcase (2) is strip-shaped; subcase (1) is pentagon-shaped with y -axis support, outside the theory, and was handled purely computationally. For the 19 rows with $k = 1$, the absence of the mechanism is proved (under (i), $k = 1$ forces both bottom corners into column $x = 1$, so no gap column exists on either side); this does not discard those families, it only says this obstruction cannot be the reason they fail. The 4 rows with $k \geq 3$ all have b/a integral, so if their corners survive reduction the shape is not a strip and the question is moot; if some subcase were strip-shaped, Theorem 4.6 (at $d_2 = 2$) or the certificates of Theorem 4.5 (at $d_2 = 3$) would apply, and $d_2 \geq 4$ would be open. Of the 9 unknown $k = 2$ rows, one, the second reduced branch of (8, 28) itself, has $d_2 = 2$ and would land in the proved cell if it strip-reduces; the other eight are y -axis flagged.

Two summary points. First, on current reduction data the proved (2, 2) theorem has exactly one client among all families with degree ≤ 150 : the open (8, 28) subcase (2), which is the case it was built for. Second, no family with degree ≤ 150 is known to need the wide-strip cells (2, 3), (2, 4), (k , 3): Section 4 is theory completeness and preparation for degrees beyond 150, not coverage at 150. We prefer stating this plainly to implying breadth the table does not support.

8 Computational verification

Pipeline and companion claim. The computational campaign behind this note transcribes the Proposition 4.3 polygon data into the full bracket system (1) (one equation per Minkowski point, plus corner saturation), runs the level-ordered unit-pivot elimination and a generic-chart decomposition, and hands each resulting stratum to the Gröbner engine msolve [2]. The companion claim documented in the repository is: subcase (2) of Proposition 4.3 has no solutions over any field of characteristic zero, each stratum returning the unit ideal over $\mathbb{Q}$ and at two to three large primes on two independent machines. That claim is conditional on Proposition 4.3 itself; we note that [4, 5, 6, 7] are arXiv-only and unrefereed (versions pinned in the repository, [7] at v1), while [3] is published with one corollary present only in the arXiv version. The theorems of Sections 3 and 4 are unconditional statements about strip pairs; only their application to (72, 108) inherits the dependency. Theorem 3.4 replaces the Gröbner verdict on the generic chart by a proof, and derives the $\{a_2 = 0\} \cup \{a_6 = 0\}$ split under which the remaining strata were computed. Subcase (1) is not claimed in this paper.

Verification methodology. Every displayed reduction is assertion-locked in re-runnable exact-arithmetic scripts: a replay of the full pipeline with per-equation provenance (reproducing the ten-event chain of Section 5 symbolically), an independent block-local engine that re-derives Propositions 3.2, 3.3 and the reduction tables from corner data alone, and a third layer that solves the column relations (2) in exact rational arithmetic, cross-checks them against a lattice-determinant enumeration of every block key, and carries the resultant certificates of Theorems 4.1, 4.3, 4.5. Each write-up stage was then subjected to adversarial review by a separate session instructed to break it, using independently written code (own hull and lattice enumeration, own substitution engine, fresh random points). These reviews confirmed the derivations and produced three substantive corrections that this paper incorporates: the gap condition must be stated side-symmetrically (a swapped-orientation family collapses even though the original asymmetric condition fails for it); the chart-free conclusion is radical membership, not ideal membership (Remark 3.5, found via a dual-number counterexample); and numerical torus probes at $(3, 3)$, $(4, 3)$, $(5, 3)$ had reported solvable systems that are in fact empty, a false positive of tolerance against multiplicity-three forced zeros, subsequently replaced by the exact certificates of Theorem 4.5. We accordingly treat numerical verdicts as untrusted throughout: every load-bearing statement above rests on displayed proofs or exact-arithmetic certificates. The scripts, run logs, review documents and pinned versions are collected at github.com/dcpesch/jc72108 (to be made public alongside this note).

AI assistance. This work was carried out as a human-directed campaign using AI systems (Anthropic Claude models, including the Fable model listed as an author). The AI performed the eliminations, noticed the -1 collapse and conjectured the vertex-gap mechanism from it, wrote the verification and certificate scripts, served as adversarial reviewer in separate sessions with independent code, and drafted this text. The human author directed the campaign, set the verification standards, checked the mathematics, and takes responsibility for the claims. We disclose this in line with emerging community norms on AI assistance in mathematics; we believe the unusual density of machine verification here (exact arithmetic, assertion-locked scripts, adversarial replication) is the appropriate standard for AI-assisted claims, and note that two of the corrections above were found by AI review of AI-produced mathematics.

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